Support Ticket Triage and Prioritization Guide

Document ID	CS-007
Department	Product and Customer Support
Document type	Guide
Owner	Head of Support
Version	3.4
Status	APPROVED
Effective / last reviewed	2025-04-07
Audience	Customer Success, Support and Engineering staff
Related documents	CS-003, CS-001, SEC-005

Summary. Step-by-step guide for Support Engineers on triaging customer tickets in NorthAssist, assigning P1 to P4 priority, choosing the tier-correct response clock, handling security-related reports, and escalating by level with worked examples and edge cases.

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1. Purpose and Scope

This guide tells Support Engineers, Support Leads and on-call Engineering managers how to triage a new customer ticket in NorthAssist: collect the right information, classify the priority, start the correct clock for the customer's support tier, route the ticket, and escalate when it does not progress. It exists so that two engineers looking at the same ticket assign the same priority and take the same first action.

It applies to every ticket received through the NorthAssist portal, email, phone, or a Customer Success Manager (CSM). It covers the Northstar Nexus Platform, Nexus Connect and Nexus Insight. Response and resolution targets by tier are defined in CS-003 and are summarised here for convenience; if the two ever differ, CS-003 prevails. Overall support principles are in CS-001. Suspected security incidents follow SEC-005 in addition to this guide.

2. Definitions

- **Ticket**: a customer request or incident record in NorthAssist.
- **Priority**: the customer-facing urgency level, P1 Critical, P2 High, P3 Medium or P4 Low.
- **Severity (internal)**: the Engineering production-incident level SEV1 to SEV4, used only when a ticket becomes a production incident. Priority and severity are different scales and must not be confused.
- **Support tier**: the customer's contract tier, Standard, Premier or Enterprise.
- **First response**: the first substantive reply by a Support Engineer that acknowledges the issue and states the next step. An automatic acknowledgement does not count.
- **Business hours**: 9:00-19:00 IST, Monday to Friday, excluding company holidays.
- **Workaround**: a documented way to restore the customer's business function without a code fix.
- **Reason code**: the mandatory field in NorthAssist that records why a ticket was escalated or reprioritised.

3. Roles and Responsibilities

- **Support Engineer (Level 1)**: triages new tickets, assigns the initial priority, sends the first response and keeps the customer updated.
- **Support Lead (Level 2)**: owns priority disputes, reviews all P1 and P2 tickets, and receives auto-escalations.
- **Director of Customer Success or Engineering on-call manager (Level 3)**: takes escalations that need Engineering decisions or management attention.
- **VP Customer Success (Level 4)**: owns customer relationship risk on long-running P1 incidents.
- **CEO executive sponsor (Level 5)**: involved for Enterprise customers only.
- **Head of Support**: owns this guide and reviews triage quality monthly.
- **CSM**: is informed of every P1 and P2 for their accounts and manages the commercial relationship.

4. Triage Overview

Triage is a six-step sequence that Level 1 must complete on every ticket:

1 Identify the customer and tier.
2 Check the ticket has the required information.
3 Classify the priority using the decision table.
4 Start the correct response clock and send the first response.
5 Route the ticket to the right queue or person.
6 Record the reason code for any reprioritisation or escalation.

For a P1, steps 3 to 5 happen together and immediately; do not wait for missing information before responding.

5. Step 1 and 2: Identify the Customer and Complete the Ticket

5.1 Identify the tier

Open the account in NorthAssist and read the support tier (Standard, Premier or Enterprise). Never infer the tier from the customer's size or from what the customer says. If the tier is missing or in dispute, treat the ticket at the higher of the stated tiers until the CSM confirms, and note this in the ticket.

5.2 Required ticket information

Every ticket needs the following before it can be worked in depth:

- Tenant ID
- Workspace name
- Nexus version
- Request ID
- Timestamp with timezone
- Steps to reproduce
- Impact statement

If something is missing, ask for it in the first response. For P1 and P2 tickets the engineer must not hold the ticket waiting for the information: begin investigating with what is known, and collect the rest in parallel. For P3 and P4 tickets the ticket may be set to "waiting for customer" until the

missing items arrive.

The Nexus version should be checked against CS-006. A ticket on a version outside support (for example 4.3, whose support ended on 2026-06-03) is handled as upgrade guidance rather than defect investigation, except that a P1 still receives a full response.

5.3 Error codes

If the customer quotes a Nexus code, use CS-002 for the first-line resolution. The common ones are:

Code	Meaning	First action
NX-1001	Authentication failure	Rotate the API token in Workspace settings
NX-2004	Connector timeout	Check endpoint latency; default timeout 30 seconds, may be raised up to 120 seconds
NX-3010	Rate limit exceeded	Use backoff and Retry-After; limit is 1,000 requests per minute per tenant
NX-4003	Schema mismatch in a Pipeline	Re-map fields and check the Connector version
NX-5000	Internal error	Collect the request ID and open a P2 or higher ticket

NX-5000 is special: because it indicates an internal error, the ticket must be at least P2 regardless of how the customer describes it.

6. Step 3: Classify the Priority

6.1 Priority definitions

Priority	Name	Definition
P1	Critical	Production is down or customer data is at risk
P2	High	A major feature is impaired
P3	Medium	Partial impairment with a workaround available
P4	Low	A question or a cosmetic issue

6.2 Decision rules

Apply the following questions in order and stop at the first yes:

1 Is production unavailable for the customer, or is there any sign that customer data is lost, corrupted or exposed? If yes, P1.
2 Is a major feature (for example Pipeline execution, authentication, or a key Connector) failing for a significant portion of the customer's users or Workspaces, with no acceptable workaround? If yes, P2.
3 Is something impaired but a workaround exists that lets the customer continue the business function? If yes, P3.
4 Is it a how-to question, a feature request, a documentation query, or a cosmetic issue? If yes, P4.

Customer-stated urgency is an input, not a decision. A customer who writes "URGENT" for a cosmetic issue is still a P4, but the engineer must acknowledge the concern politely and explain the classification. Equally, a customer who understates a production outage must be classified by the facts, which makes it a P1.

6.3 Data-at-risk rule

Any ticket indicating that customer data may have been exposed to the wrong party, lost, or altered incorrectly is P1, even if the product is otherwise working. Examples include a Connector writing records to the wrong Workspace and a Webhook sending payloads to an unintended endpoint. In addition, the engineer must report the possible security incident to the Security Desk immediately (see section 9).

6.4 Priority adjustments

Priority may be changed by the Support Lead during the life of a ticket. A change requires a reason code in NorthAssist and a note to the customer. Typical reasons are a workaround is found (P1 to P2 or P2 to P3), impact turns out to be wider than reported (up), or the issue turns out to be a configuration question (down to P4). Priority must not be lowered merely to avoid missing a response target.

6.5 Worked classification examples

Example 1: A Premier customer in Hyderabad writes that all their Pipelines have stopped since 14:10 IST and their order feed to the warehouse is blocked. Production is down for them. Priority is P1. The Level 1 engineer sends a first response within the Premier P1 target of 30 minutes, pages or notifies the Support Lead, and starts diagnostics.

Example 2: A Standard customer reports that one scheduled report in Nexus Insight fails every morning, but they can run it manually. A workaround exists. Priority is P3.

Example 3: An Enterprise customer asks whether Webhooks support signing. This is a question. Priority is P4, and the answer is given using the compatibility notes in CS-006.

Example 4: A Standard customer reports NX-3010 on a nightly batch that sends bursts above the rate limit. The customer's business is not down and backoff resolves it. Priority is P3, with a configuration recommendation.

Example 5: A customer reports NX-5000 for Workspace configuration saves, affecting several administrators. NX-5000 is at least P2 by rule, and because no workaround exists it stays P2.

7. Step 4: Response Clocks and Updates

7.1 Support hours by tier

Standard tier gets support in business hours, 9:00-19:00 IST Monday to Friday, excluding company holidays. Premier and Enterprise tiers have 24x7 coverage for P1 and P2. For all tiers P3 and P4 are handled in business hours.

7.2 First-response targets

Priority	Standard	Premier	Enterprise
P1	1 hour (business hours)	30 minutes	15 minutes
P2	4 business hours	2 hours	1 hour

Priority	Standard	Premier	Enterprise
P3	1 business day	4 business hours	2 business hours
P4	2 business days	1 business day	1 business day

The clock starts when the ticket is created in NorthAssist, or when the customer's phone call is logged. A ticket opened outside coverage hours starts its business-hours clock at the next start of business hours.

7.3 Update frequency

- P1: an update every 60 minutes; for Enterprise customers every 30 minutes.
- P2: an update every 4 hours; for Enterprise customers every 2 hours.
- P3: an update every 2 business days.
- P4: an update every week.

Target workaround or resolution time for P1 is 8 hours for Standard, 6 hours for Premier and 4 hours for Enterprise.

7.4 First response content

A good first response is plain and empathetic, free of blame, and contains four things: confirmation that the ticket is understood, the priority assigned and why, the next action and who is doing it, and the time of the next update. It must not contain internal system names, personal data, or delivery dates that Engineering has not confirmed. It is written in English, or in Hindi on request for India customers. Use approved templates from the communication library.

Example: "We have confirmed that Pipeline runs in your Workspace Orders-Prod have stopped since 14:10 IST. We have classified this as P1 and an engineer is investigating now. Our next update will be at 15:10 IST."

8. Step 5: Routing

8.1 Where the ticket goes

Situation	Route to
Configuration, how-to, known code with documented fix	Level 1 resolves using CS-002
Reproducible defect on a supported version	Support Lead opens a defect with Engineering
P1 or P2 with no known cause	Support Lead plus Engineering on-call via the page process
Possible security issue	Security Desk plus Support Lead (section 9)
Contract, billing or credit question	CSM, with Finance as needed (see CS-009)
Feature request	Product Manager via the feature request queue; ticket closed as P4

8.2 Declaring an incident

If a P1 or P2 ticket is caused by a platform-side problem, the Support Lead requests that Engineering declare a production incident. Engineering then assigns a severity (SEV1 or SEV2) and an Incident Commander. Once a SEV1 or SEV2 is declared, the first customer notification must be issued within 30 minutes through Northstar Status, and by email to affected Enterprise and Premier contacts. Support must not describe the incident differently from the Communications

Lead's wording.

8.3 Duplicates and related tickets

If several customers report the same fault, link the tickets to a single parent in NorthAssist and let the parent carry the technical investigation. Each child ticket still needs its own tier-based updates, so the Support Lead should assign a single owner to send updates in bulk using the approved template.

9. Security-Related Tickets

A ticket that suggests a security issue must be handled in two tracks at once: the customer track (triage as above) and the security track (SEC-005).

Treat these as potential security incidents:

- A customer reports seeing data belonging to another customer.
- A customer reports suspected compromise of an API token or credential.
- A customer reports unexpected Connector or Webhook activity they did not configure.
- A customer reports a vulnerability in the product.

What to do:

1. Classify the ticket as P1 if customer data may be at risk, otherwise at least P2.
2. Report to the Security Desk immediately, by email to security@northstar-systems.example or by hotline ext. 5555.
3. Do not discuss the possible cause in the customer ticket until the Incident Response Lead has agreed the wording.
4. For a suspected token compromise, advise the customer to rotate the API token in Workspace settings straight away. This is safe to say, because it is also the documented fix for NX-1001.
5. Keep all evidence, such as request IDs and timestamps, in the ticket; do not delete or edit comments.

Customer notification of a confirmed breach affecting their data is made within 72 hours of confirmation, under the contractual commitment (illustrative; to be verified by Legal before external use). The Privacy Officer decides on notification of personal-data breaches, not Support.

10. Escalation

10.1 Escalation levels

Level	Who	Typical trigger
1	Support Engineer	Default owner
2	Support Lead	P1 or P2, stuck ticket, priority dispute
3	Director of Customer Success or Engineering on-call manager	Engineering decision or management attention needed
4	VP Customer Success	Prolonged P1 or relationship risk
5	CEO executive sponsor	Enterprise customers only

10.2 Automatic escalation for P1

A P1 that is unresolved escalates automatically: at 2 hours it goes to Level 2, at 4 hours to Level 3, and at 8 hours to Level 4. These timings are from ticket creation. The engineer does not need to wait for the automatic escalation if the situation obviously needs a higher level sooner.

10.3 Customer-requested escalation

When a customer asks for an escalation, the request must be acknowledged within 1 hour during business hours. The engineer must not argue with the customer or delay the request. The Support Lead reviews the ticket and contacts the customer. Every escalation, customer-requested or automatic, is recorded in NorthAssist with a reason code.

10.4 Escalation worked example

A Standard customer opens a P1 at 10:00 IST on a Tuesday because production Pipelines are failing. At 12:00 the ticket moves to Level 2 automatically, at 14:00 to Level 3, and at 18:00 to Level 4. If the customer is Enterprise, the CSM is informed at the start, updates go out every 30 minutes, and the CEO executive sponsor may be engaged by the VP Customer Success if the issue is still open after the Level 4 stage.

11. Edge Cases and Exceptions

- **Ticket arrives outside business hours from a Standard customer**: a P1 from a Standard customer is still assessed immediately for data-at-risk. If data is at risk, the Security Desk and on-call manager must be contacted, even though the standard business-hours target applies to the response clock. Raise the case with the Support Lead.
- **Customer on an unsupported version**: P1 still receives a response; the permanent resolution is an upgrade (CS-006).
- **Customer disputes the tier**: work at the higher tier, then settle with the CSM.
- **Customer sends the same issue by email, phone and portal**: merge into one ticket and keep the earliest creation time.
- **Customer will not provide required information on a P3 or P4**: after two reminders over 4 business days, the ticket may be closed as "no response" with a clear note. It may be reopened by the customer.
- **Public holiday**: business-hours clocks do not run on company holidays for Standard, but P1 and P2 for Premier and Enterprise continue 24x7.
- **Language**: Hindi can be provided on request for India customers; other languages are not guaranteed.
- **Requests for delivery dates**: never promise a date without Engineering confirmation.

12. Quality Checks

The Head of Support reviews a sample of tickets monthly against this guide. The reviewer looks at:

1 Was the priority correct against section 6?
2 Was the first response inside the tier target?
3 Were updates sent at the required frequency?
4 Was every escalation recorded with a reason code?
5 Were security tickets reported to the Security Desk immediately?

Repeated misclassification is addressed through coaching, not blame. Misclassification that delayed a customer fix is reviewed in the weekly Support quality meeting.

13. Frequently Asked Questions

What priority is a customer's request for a how-to? P4.

What priority is NX-5000? At least P2, because it is an internal error and needs a request ID.

Who gets a P1 escalation after 4 hours? Level 3, the Director of Customer Success or the Engineering on-call manager.

How quickly must a customer-requested escalation be acknowledged? Within 1 hour in business hours.

Can I lower a priority to meet the target? No. Priority changes need a reason code and must reflect the facts.

14. Related Documents

- CS-003 for response, resolution and uptime commitments by tier.
- CS-001 for the overall support operating model.
- SEC-005 for security incident response, which runs alongside triage for security-related tickets.
- CS-002 for the Nexus troubleshooting codes, CS-006 for version support, and CS-009 for credits and refunds.

15. Revision History

Version	Effective date	Change
3.0	2024-11-04	Added data-at-risk rule and security track
3.4	2025-04-07	Aligned response tables with CS-003; added edge cases